work to be explored throughout this chapter, she calls for alternate forms of inscription: “we did not need to go to the graveyard / for affirmation.”[32]

Upon her arrival in West Berlin in April 1984, Lorde promptly wrote in her journal that within a week’s time she found an emerging sense of balance and new possibilities for her life.[33] Lorde was taken in and taken aback by Berlin, a city that led her to new paths of recovery, haunted her, and became a site of immense productivity. Berlin offered an archive of poetic imagery and ideas. Lorde drew from her relationship to the physical environment of the city in all of her writing about her experiences there. There, she was aware of how her multiple intersecting identities (black, lesbian, poet, and American, among other distinctions) marked her as an outsider but also gave her opportunities to work across difference on both sides of the city’s internal divides. She encountered active silences about racism and anti-Semitism maintained in the long shadow of Nazism encoded in the city’s public spaces, and she at once repurposed them as sites in which to speak out against injustice. Lorde turned to divided Berlin as a space of self-fulfillment, homeopathic treatment, critical confrontation, and habitual return for poetic work, and those close to her contend her trips to the city added years to her life and new layers of meaning to her work.[34]

Lorde’s initial encounters in the divided city prompted poetic exploration. For example, the unpublished, free-verse poem “First Impressions”—which she began as a journal entry on May 2, 1984, a month into her first trip to Berlin, and then typed out and revised in three iterations on May 15—exemplifies how Berlin’s historically traumatized urban spaces served as poetic points of reflection for her. In the poem, she captures her observations of life in the divided city through a series of pairings in which she addresses the concepts of home, health, and longing. Her observations are not centered on West Berlin’s sprawling layout or central divides but on its confined spaces. Here Lorde conjures Berlin as a space of intimacy as well as strained refuge. Comparable to the contemporaneous Berlin-based work of American photographer Nan Goldin, who included her portraits of women in bathrooms in *The Ballad of Sexual Dependency*,[35] which premiered the same year, Lorde begins her poem behind the locked door of a bathroom stall in West Berlin, where she processes the cultural distinctions and her challenges